

METRICSUNLOCKED · SESSION 03

The State of 1,000 Revenue-Generating Startups

What a thousand live TrustMRR profiles reveal about how startups make money — and why most of them never will.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Three Numbers That Explain Everything Else in This Deck

61%

of all revenue in the dataset is captured by just the top 10 startups — out of 1,000.

3.8x

revenue premium the median B2B startup earns over the median B2C startup.

27% / 17%

AI startups are 27% of the categorized ecosystem — but only 17% of its revenue.

Full findings, methodology, and limitations follow.

THE PROBLEM

Everyone Sees the Winners. Nobody Sees the Median.

Twitter threads, demo days, and “builder in public” dashboards showcase outliers by construction. This dataset lets us ask a plainer question: what does the typical revenue-generating startup actually look like — and what separates the few that break away from the many that don't?

\$3.6K

Median lifetime revenue across all 1,000 startups — the typical outcome.

\$334K

Mean lifetime revenue — pulled 92x higher than the median by a small number of outliers.

DATASET OVERVIEW

1,000 Startups, 65 Countries, One Frozen Snapshot

1000

live TrustMRR startup profiles,
frozen 30 Jul 2026

65

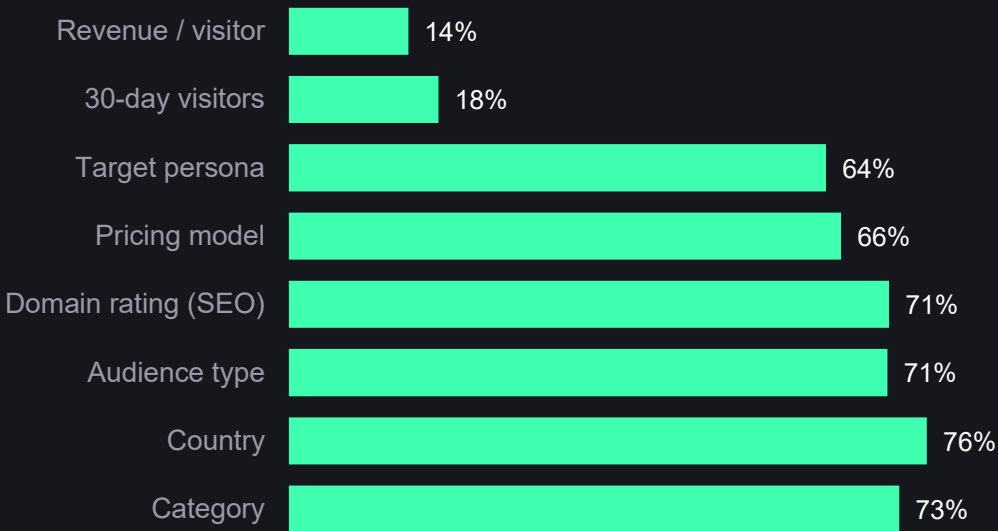
countries represented across
the dataset

73%

of startups have self-tagged a
category (726 of 1,000)

Revenue and MRR fields are complete for all 1,000 rows.
Optional profile fields — traffic, SEO, persona, pricing — are
self-reported and meaningfully incomplete. Treat findings
built on them as directional.

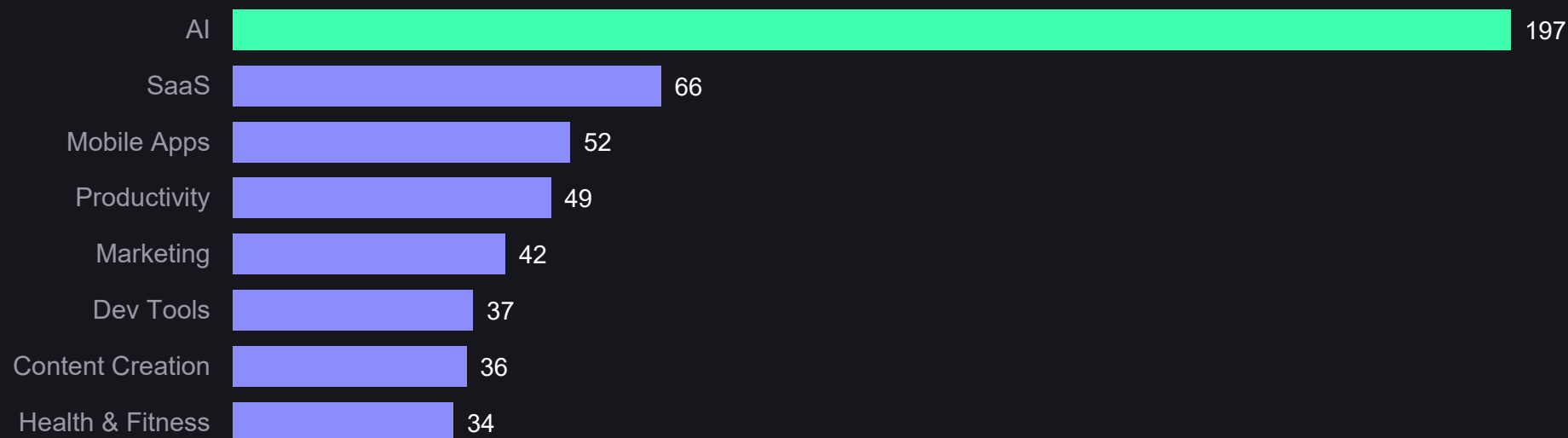
DATA COMPLETENESS BY FIELD



WHO MAKES UP THIS ECOSYSTEM — CATEGORIES

Nearly 30 Categories. One Dominates by Headcount.

STARTUPS BY CATEGORY (TOP 8 OF 29)



AI leads with 197 startups — 27% of the 726 categorized profiles. Whether that headcount converts to revenue is a different question, on slide 10.

WHO MAKES UP THIS ECOSYSTEM — GEOGRAPHY

The US Builds a Quarter of the Startups — and Takes Most of the Revenue

REVENUE BY COUNTRY, TOP 8



70%

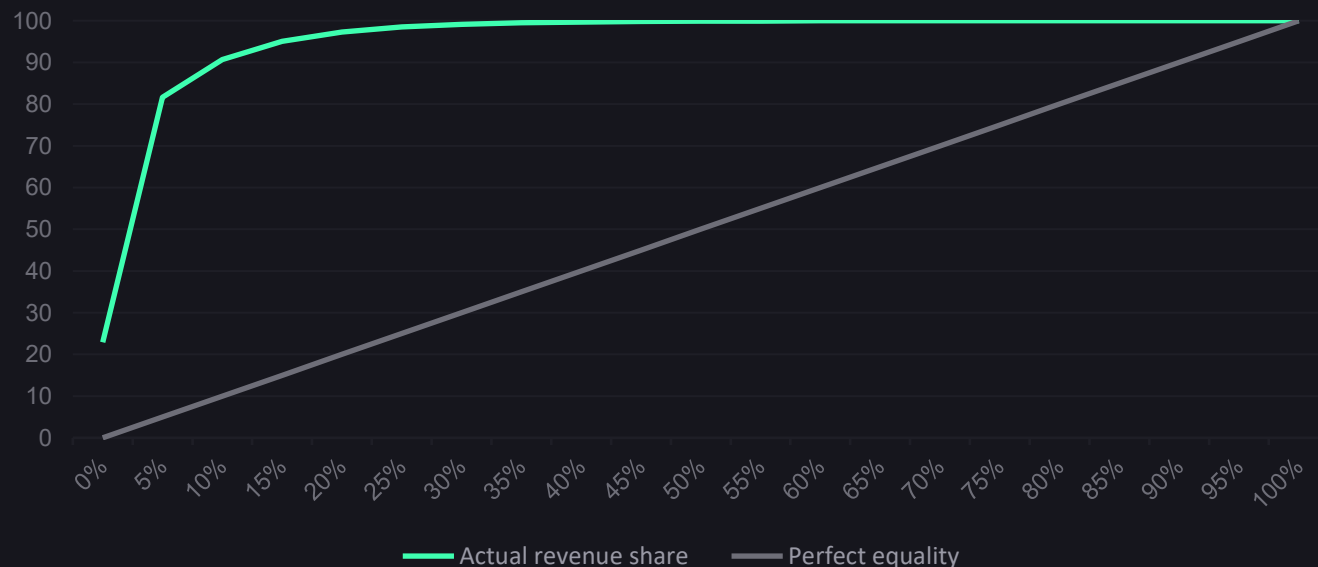
of all dataset revenue originates from US-based startups.

65

countries are represented — a long, thin tail outside the US and UK.

The Startup World Is Smaller Than It Looks

CUMULATIVE SHARE OF REVENUE vs. SHARE OF STARTUPS



61%

of total revenue held by the top 10 of 1,000 startups (top 1%).

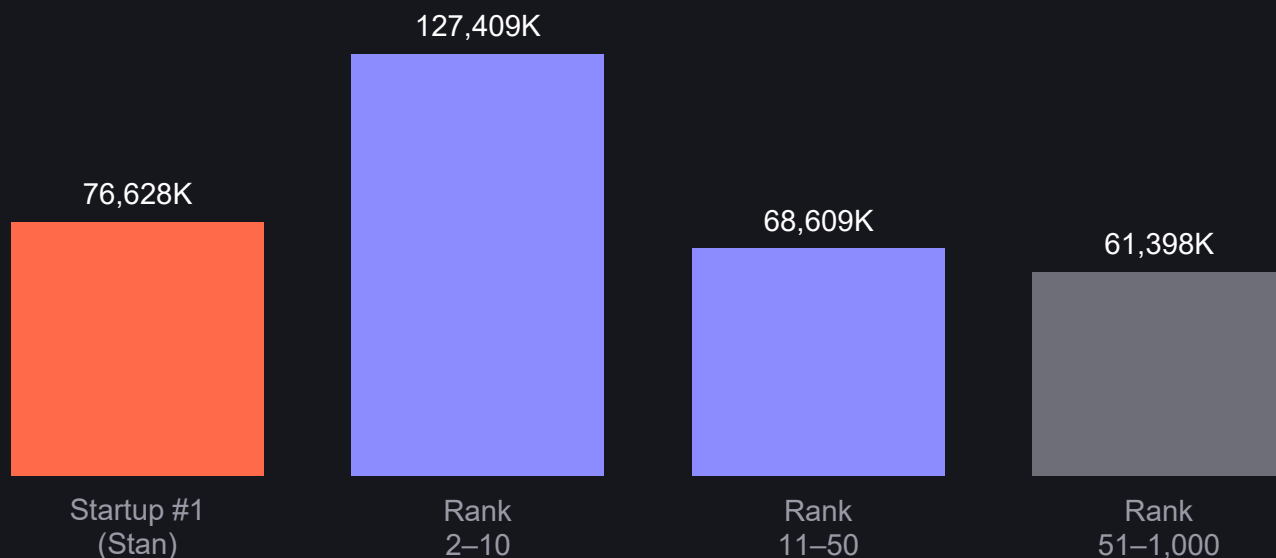
4.5%

of startups (just 45) account for 80% of all revenue in the dataset.

WHERE IS THE MONEY — CONCENTRATION

One Company Outearns 950 Others Combined

HOW \$334M IN TOTAL REVENUE BREAKS DOWN



22.9%

of all revenue in the entire 1,000-startup dataset comes from a single company. Every dataset-wide average in this deck is pulled upward by a handful of names like it — treat means with caution; we lead with medians throughout.

WHERE IS THE MONEY — THE TYPICAL CASE

Most Companies Never Reach Escape Velocity

\$3.6K

median lifetime revenue

\$282

median monthly recurring revenue

38%

of startups have made under \$1,000, ever

42

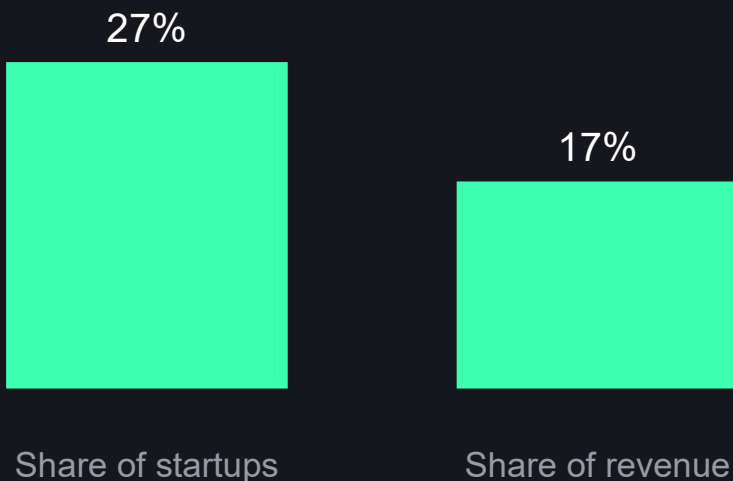
startups (4.2%) have crossed \$1M lifetime revenue

Reading this dataset as a pipeline: roughly 6 in 10 startups are pre-revenue-scale (\$3,620 median), and fewer than 1 in 20 ever cross into meaningful, durable revenue.

THE AI BOOM

AI Dominates Mindshare, Not the Wallet

AI'S SHARE OF THE CATEGORIZED ECOSYSTEM



\$4.9K

median lifetime revenue for an AI startup.

\$3.7K

median lifetime revenue for every other category — essentially the same.

AI startups are 27% of all categorized companies but only 17% of categorized revenue — and the median AI startup earns about as much as the median non-AI startup. The category is winning attention, not yet outperforming on revenue.

WHAT ACTUALLY DRIVES REVENUE

Traffic Doesn't Predict Revenue. Subscriptions Do.

CORRELATION WITH LIFETIME REVENUE (LOG-LOG)



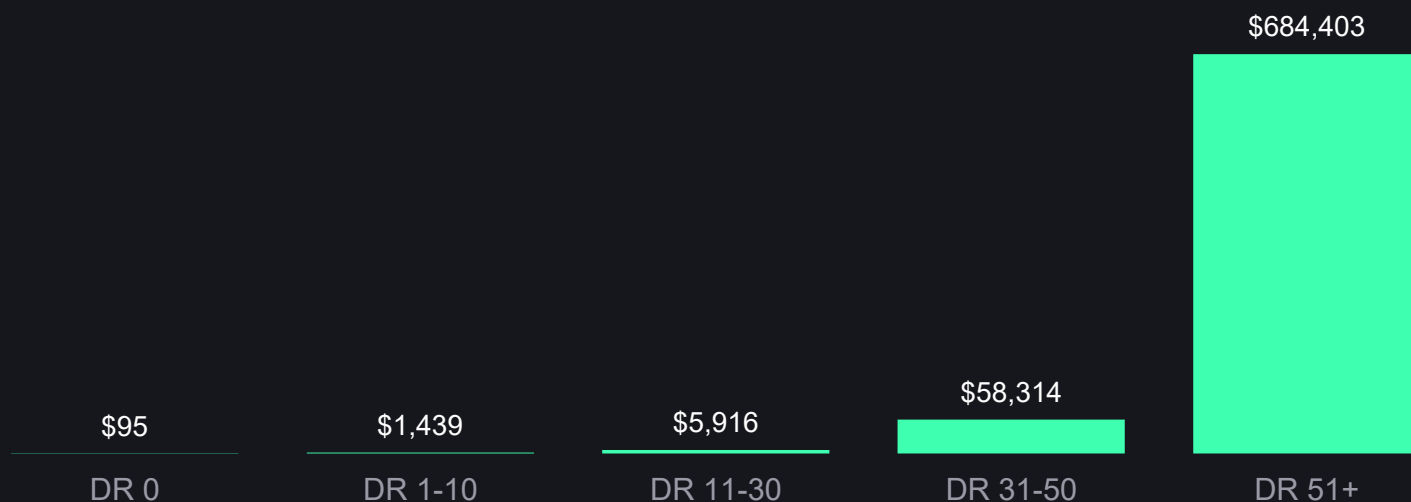
Reading this chart

A social following is the weakest signal of revenue we tested — a large audience is no guarantee of a large business. The strongest correlate is the number of people who actually pay: active subscriptions.

WHAT ACTUALLY DRIVES REVENUE — A CLOSER LOOK

Domain Authority Compounds Revenue, Step by Step

MEDIAN LIFETIME REVENUE BY DOMAIN RATING TIER



~7x

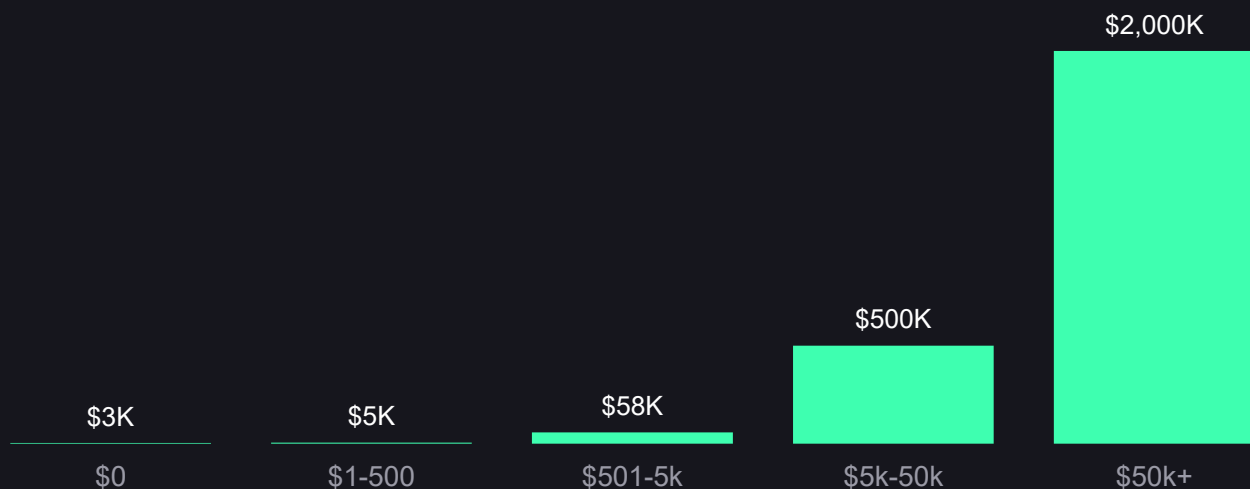
average step-up in median revenue moving from one domain-rating tier to the next.

Based on 714 startups with a recorded domain rating (28.6% missing) — directional, not causal.

ACQUISITION MARKET

The Acquisition Market Is Surprisingly Cheap

MEDIAN ASKING PRICE BY MONTHLY REVENUE (MRR)



MRR bucket of the listed startup

26%

of all 1,000 startups are currently listed for sale (262 companies).

2.3x

median asking price as a multiple of trailing revenue — well under typical SaaS M&A comps.

HIDDEN INSIGHTS

The Best-Performing Startups Often Have Almost No Audience

HIGH REVENUE, FEWER THAN 1,000 FOLLOWERS

Startup	Category	Followers	Lifetime rev.
Stack Influence	Marketing	900	\$26.3M
Stealth Company	Unlabeled	0	\$11.3M
Stealth Company	Unlabeled	106	\$5.9M
Stealth Company	Unlabeled	43	\$4.8M
Stealth Company	Unlabeled	0	\$2.6M
Stealth Company	Unlabeled	0	\$2.6M

129

startups (13%) list themselves publicly as “Stealth Company” — anonymous by choice, several earning millions.

<1,000

followers is enough, for several 7-figure startups above, to run a real business with zero social reach.

RECOMMENDATIONS

What This Means for Founders, Investors & Operators

● FOUNDERS

Audience size is the weakest revenue signal we tested — invest in SEO and subscription mechanics before follower count.

B2B pricing power is real: the median B2B startup earns 3.8x its B2C counterpart.

● INVESTORS

Power-law outcomes hold even at micro scale — 45 startups drive 80% of this ecosystem's revenue. Diligence for it.

Domain rating and subscriber count are better pre-revenue proxies than social following or category label.

● OPERATORS / ACQUIRERS

The indie acquisition market is a buyer's market — a 2.3x median multiple, well below typical SaaS M&A.

Look past follower counts and brand names — quiet, “stealth” performers are frequently the better deal.

FINAL TAKEAWAY

Most Startups Don't Fail. They Just Stay Small.

59% of this dataset's startups have never crossed \$10,000 in lifetime revenue, while a concentrated few scale into the millions. The ecosystem isn't a ladder every company climbs — it's a pyramid very few reach the top of. The data doesn't say why any single company succeeds. It does say, plainly, how rare it is.